

**a. The title that summarizes your work**

Raising Awareness of the Hidden Costs of Mandatory Participation

**b. A brief (< 1 page) statement describing the major accomplishments of your research or creative works (focus on one or two major results). This should be written for a general audience so avoid the use of disciplinary jargon.**

Day by day, digital consent is shifting from a meaningful decision into a routine action. People are clicking "agree" just to progress. What began as a privacy concern revealed a deeper pattern: constant exposure to no-opt-out systems trains people to participate automatically. As they move into early professional roles, students may carry these habits into environments where consent connects to evaluation, monitoring, and performance expectations. In this research project, I take on the challenge of supporting a generation with no real choice in developing a clearer understanding of their agency.

A major accomplishment of my project was building a strong research base through a wide range of fields, including privacy theory, data economy literature, and work on digital governance. These perspectives were helpful for understanding how imagining alternative futures can reshape a sense of responsibility in the present. This moved my work away from simple problem-solving and towards examining the systems that shape everyday behavior.

Another major accomplishment was developing a series of speculative scenarios through prototypes, both digital and physical, which aim to exaggerate familiar consent patterns. These pieces are still in development, but they already serve as conceptual tools that visualize hidden dynamics. The prototypes are not intended to predict future technologies, but to immerse viewers in complex situations, so they can recognize how easily participation becomes automatic. By externalizing these routines, the prototypes invite people entering technical fields to reflect on the systems they will eventually help create.

**c. A 2-3 page report of your research/creative experiences at Pacific, as well as how your experiences have prepared you for life after Pacific. Your report can include figures and/or pictures in addition to your narrative summary (does not count as part of your page limit). Reports with insufficient detail will not be accepted. It is strongly encouraged that you and your faculty mentor review a draft of your report before you submit it.**

### **1. Introduction**

Throughout my research on digital privacy, I noticed how often students must click “agree” to access basic tools. A recent study found that only about 9% of people read terms and conditions, with rates dropping to around 3% for people ages 18–34 (Cruz, 2025). This pattern suggests digital consent has become more of a routine action than a conscious decision, which became the starting point for my research. This action becomes muscle memory over years of repetition. Choice disappears, and the motion becomes a requirement for participation. When I looked closer, I realized this routine is not limited to school. Many of the same systems appear again when students transition into the workforce, only now the consequences are connected to performance reviews, monitoring tools, and job security. This realization motivated me to examine how students learn digital consent, how those habits carry into the first years of work, and how these systems shape one’s sense of agency.

### **2. Approach and Research Methods**

To study this issue, I used futures thinking, scenario development, and speculative prototyping (Dunne & Raby, 2024; Candy & Dungan, 2017). These methods offered a way to explore consent as something people learn gradually through repeated interactions, and not a fixed technical concept. Instead of predicting future technologies, I built scenarios that pushed current patterns to an extreme to help viewers notice the behaviors they already perform without thinking. This approach allowed me to examine digital consent through multiple angles and to create experiences that make invisible routines visible.

### **3. The Question of Agency**

What does agency look like for a generation that has always had to click “agree” in order to move forward?

This question shaped the direction of the project and pushed me past describing how systems work and towards examining how people learn certain digital behaviors over time. It emphasizes how repeated agreement becomes routine, how those routines carry into early professional environments, and how expectations about control are formed long before an individual enters the workplace.

#### **4. Framing the Work Through Speculative Scenario Prototyping**

In this project, I designed and developed prototypes that function as speculative scenarios. Each one takes an ordinary digital routine and exaggerates it just enough to reveal the pressures that usually stay hidden. My goal is to present these interactive engagements through temporary exhibition installations, potentially on the university campus, allowing students to interact with them directly.

Rather than predicting future technologies, these prototypes explore how familiar patterns, agreeing to proceed, being monitored, responding to automated cues, or managing performance, begin to shape expectations over time. Treating the prototypes as scenarios allowed me to approach consent as something learned through repetition, not simply a one-time choice. This approach also clarified the role of each piece: a forced-choice screen that removes the option to refuse, a jumping game built on repeated agreement, a clock made from everyday micro-consents, and a wearable that turns performance into something visible. Together, these works create situations that show how easily participation becomes automatic and set up the prototype descriptions that follow.

##### **4-1: Forced Participation: The Button That Never Lets You Say No**

This prototype presents two buttons that will be 3d modeled, Agree and Disagree, with only the former working. The red “Disagree” button looks functional but will be purposefully jammed, forcing the user to have no other option but to “Agree” to a mock interface asking them to share their data. This piece highlights how often digital systems frame consent as a choice while steering users toward a single acceptable action. It reflects a common reality: even when people attempt to select the alternative, the system redirects them toward participation. This makes viewers confront how “choice” is often simulated rather than real.

##### **4-2: Tap to Agree: A Three-Level Consent Game**

In this early screen of the Tap to Agree prototype (Figure 1), the player is asked to click “agree” before starting a simple jump-based game. This version is a visual Figma mock-up, the full interactive version is currently being developed using Java. The goal of this prototype is to be a fun interactive way to display how the familiar action of clicking “agree” begins, and how it can quietly become the first step in a system where progression depends on repeated consent. Even in this initial screen, the player’s only real option is to accept the terms in order to move forward, setting up the logic that the later levels of the game will exaggerate.



*Figure 1. Initial screen of the “Tap to Agree” prototype.*

#### **4-3: Routine Clock: Habitual Consent**

This physical prototype replaces the numbers on a clock with everyday micro-consent actions such as logging in, accepting cookies, turning in assignments, or responding to workplace messages. The piece will include phrases like “Verify identity”, “Accept cookies”, and “Allow notifications”. By mapping these actions onto the cycle of a day, the clock shows how easily school routines merge into workplace routines. It reveals how consent becomes a learned rhythm, something performed without consideration.

#### **4-4: Performance Glow Wearable: When Your Metrics Become Visible**

This scenario imagines a workplace where your shirt glows based on your performance data. What was once hidden on a dashboard becomes part of your appearance. The wearable exaggerates how workplace analytics already influence behavior by making performance visible to everyone, not just the system. It reflects how quickly private data can become public pressure once workers are conditioned to constant monitoring.

### **6. Reflection and Purpose**

The goal of this work is not to offer solutions or to imagine accurate future technologies. Instead, it hopes to bring students and early workers into contact with the systems they already participate in. Through experiencing these exaggerated scenarios, viewers can reconsider their assumptions on consent, control, and responsibility. This is particularly important for engineering and computer science students, who often focus on problem solving without considering the larger environments their work will shape. The project encourages them to see themselves not only as implementers but as contributors to the conditions in which others must live and work.

### **7. Preparing for Life After Pacific**

This project changed how I think about technology as a computer science student. I no longer see systems only as tools, but as powerful mechanisms that teach behaviors and establish expectations. Building the prototypes made this clearer, because designing them forced me to

pay attention to the patterns people usually overlook. Guided by a faculty mentor, I used my skills and imagination to turn these concepts into early prototypes that make the patterns visible. This perspective will carry into my path in data science, where choices about consent and data use shape the systems people depend on. This project showed me that my role is not just to work with data but to help shape the conditions built around it. It also prepared me to help others question the systems they interact with, which will matter in the workplaces and communities I move into after Pacific.

## **References**

Candy, Stuart, and Jake Dunagan. "Designing an experiential scenario: The people who vanished." *Futures* 86 (2017): 136-153.

Cruz, Brett. "Americans Get an F on Digital Privacy Knowledge." *Security.Org*, 1 Apr. 2025, [www.security.org/digital-security/american-digital-privacy-knowledge/](https://www.security.org/digital-security/american-digital-privacy-knowledge/).

Dunne, Anthony, and Fiona Raby. *Speculative Everything*, With a new preface by the authors: Design, Fiction, and Social Dreaming. MIT press, 2024.